

as Viagogo, prices soared to Rs. 4,500 and later to Rs. 13,000. A VIP seat listed at Rs. 1,06,959 sold out quickly. By Saturday, *BookMyShow* changed its listing to “event closed,” without ever reopening sales.

At the venue, fans pressed against the gates, hoping for a glimpse of Smriti Mandhana or Harmanpreet Kaur as India trained. The stadium authorities confirmed the match was sold out, while *BookMyShow* posted, “Due to the overwhelming response, tickets were sold out in no time.” Even the players weren’t spared ticket requests. “You know how it is for tickets (in India). Very happy that the pressure is there for cricket and tickets too!” Harmanpreet laughed.

A D.Y. Patil University student said, “People often comment about an inferiority in women’s cricket, but no one wants to miss an ‘I was there’ moment if India wins.” The chaos echoed the 2023 Men’s World Cup fiasco, with similar black-market sales.

To ease fan travel, the local train “mega block” was even called off for the day, a rare gesture by city authorities. By afternoon, the D.Y. Patil stands were a sea of blue, as 39,555 fans watched Harmanpreet and her team cross the finish line in emphatic fashion.

Lavanya Lakshmi Narayanan

A DAY OF COLOUR FOR PUNE'S YOUNG FANS

Meanwhile, nearly 300 underprivileged children from Pune filled Level 1 of Block E with colour and rhythm during the India–Australia semifinal.

The group, aged between eight and 15, came through



an initiative by 68-year-old social worker and cricket enthusiast Shashank Wagh. They represented three institutions: Manavya (supporting HIV-affected children), Ishwarpuram Sanstha (for NorthEastern students), and Sumati Balwan School.

Before the match, the children toured Mumbai landmarks, including the Atal Setu, Gateway of India, and Marine Drive, before heading to Nerul to cheer for the

Women in Blue. Carrying flags and dhols, they sang and danced to “*Jeetega India*.”

“I always try to do something for underprivileged children. Seeing the joy on their faces is my reward,” Wagh told *Sportstar*. “We arranged everything: travel, meals, snacks, and sightseeing. I’m thankful to my friends and the Exim Integrated Club for their support.”

For these children, it wasn’t just a match; it was a lifetime memory.

Amol Karhadkar

WHEN SCROLLS TURNED TO GAZES

South Africa lost the final but walked away having won plenty of hearts — none more than skipper Laura Wolvaardt, who amassed 571 runs, the most in a single



edition of the tournament. In Navi Mumbai, an appreciative crowd rose to its feet when she brought up her second consecutive century in the final. Loud cheers followed her post-match speech too.

A few days earlier in Guwahati, where South Africa recorded a famous win in the first semifinal to knock England out of the competition, Wolvaardt’s sublime form turned neutral fans into believers. Young volunteers from the anthem ceremony and spectators with no allegiance to either side could be seen on their phones, playing video games during the early slog overs. But in the final 10 overs of the Proteas innings, Wolvaardt shifted gears, finding boundaries at will. From the press box just behind them, journalists watched as gaming screens gave way to camera lenses; the same kids now recording her innings and searching for her story online.

Ever the analytical mind, Wolvaardt drew positives from the campaign. “Maybe I was being a bit too conservative or one-dimensional. To win games, you’ve got to be positive and aggressive. I explored a bit of that in this tournament.”

Lavanya Lakshmi Narayanan